Week 13

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 4 · LESSON 1

Morality

BIG IDEA

Many students are taught that right and wrong are just opinions, so when we teach morality they may hear only our opinion. But we can't measure ourselves by ourselves: our sense of right and wrong needs a standard beyond us, and it points us to God.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Morality seems simple, but students are often taught that moral claims are opinion. When we speak about truth, some hear only what we happen to think.
2. Meet with your small group leaders: talk through what they may hear, and gather students' views on right and wrong. Some answers may surprise you.
3. As a teacher, the speaker found students copying homework in the hallway. Asked whether it was wrong, they simply said no, with no reason given.
4. Schools often label anything about feelings or beliefs as opinion, and that slope runs from copying homework to equality, murder and marriage.
5. Little Johnny measured himself as "one Johnny tall." We can't measure ourselves by ourselves; morality needs an external standard, and that points to God.
6. Respond with grace and love and truly listen, learn where their ideas come from, then challenge their thinking with care. Share this with your small group leaders.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Where do I present my views as obvious fact without explaining where my morals come from?
2. How do I react when a student pushes back, and can I listen without taking offense?
3. What do my small group leaders need to hear from me before this week's discussions?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What's the difference between a fact and an opinion when it comes to right and wrong?
2. Where do most of your ideas about right and wrong come from: school, home, online or media?
3. Is anything wrong for everyone, everywhere, no matter what they think? How would you know?
4. What did the "one Johnny tall" story show you about needing a standard beyond ourselves?
5. When you disagree with someone about right and wrong, how can you listen well and still be honest?

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WEEK 13 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Morality is not simple

0:05 All right, so this week we're talking about morality. It might seem on the surface that talking about morality is pretty straightforward, right? It's right versus wrong. It's what we should be doing and what we shouldn't be doing, and we're really comparing all of that to God as the standard. So it seems pretty straightforward, pretty simple. But I want you to take a second and step back, because it may not be as simple as you think, or as you hope. I want you to think for a minute about what we're really asking students to do.

0:45 We're asking them to differentiate between right and wrong. And we're asking them to do that when they're taught that some of the things we're talking about are just a little bit more than mere opinion. Students are taught on a whole different level than maybe what we're used to, so you're going to experience something that maybe you don't realize you're going to experience. We stand on stage as leaders, and we're talking about Jesus, and we're talking about truth, and we're talking about these fundamental facts about the Christian faith, and we're telling them what they ought to be doing and what they ought not to be doing.

1:21 Students can often be looking at us while we're thinking we're talking about fact. We're thinking we're talking about pretty black-and-white kinds of things, and that may not necessarily be the case, when some of our students are looking up to us and thinking, "Well, that's your opinion. That's what you think, and I'm not sure I actually want to agree with your opinion."

Meet with your small group leaders

1:43 So this is a good week. It's a good time to take a step back. Make sure you meet with your small group leaders, and make sure you talk through a little bit about what they might experience in their small groups. Talk a little bit about some feedback you can get from the students about some of the things you're talking about from the main stage: about what their thoughts are on right versus wrong, and what they're being taught in school, and how they feel about certain topics. You might be comforted, but you also might be surprised, and you might get some answers that you're not real thrilled with. But it's a good starting point, and something you can continue to work through.

Copying homework in the hallway

2:30 I'll never forget, back when I was teaching, I'd walk in in the morning and you'd be stepping through the hallways. You had to literally step over all of the students who were sitting in the hallways and talking, all these great conversations and activity going on in the hallways. It was a great sort of experience in the morning, seeing some students' smiling faces and other students' not-so-smiling faces. It was awesome. And one day at a teacher's meeting, we got

talking about some of the students, and we realized something that most of us were completely blind to: the students were doing more than just sitting in the hallways hanging out. The students were sitting in the hallways copying each other's homework for their first class, or their first couple of classes throughout the day.

3:14 Some of us talked about it: well, are they collaborating and working together on something, or are they just straight-up copying their homework, which would obviously be wrong? So we talked about it, we debated it a little bit, and then we decided, well, let's confront some of our students. Let's talk it through with some of our students. Maybe they just don't realize what they're doing, which would seem strange, but maybe they don't realize that what they're doing is wrong.

3:37 So we pulled a few students aside, with no intention of getting them in trouble, and just said, "Hey, what are you doing in the hallways in the morning?" And with no regard for possibly getting in trouble, or having us call their parents, or some kind of consequence coming down on them, they just said, "Yeah, we're just copying homework. That's what we're doing. No big deal." So we asked them, "Well, do you think this is wrong?" The response was simple: "Well, no." "Well, why not?" "Well, because we just don't." That was their answer. They just don't.

Fact or opinion

4:13 And if you do a little bit of research into the world of education, and what students are being taught is right and wrong, it's actually becoming closer and closer to what we consider to be opinion. Students are being taught that any time we use words like "feeling," or what they believe, or what they think, it's simply an opinion. Well, this is sort of causing some problems, right? Because now we start talking about things well beyond copying homework as being an opinion.

4:45 When we say things like, well, are all men, or all people, created equally? Is that a fact, or is that an opinion? What about: it's wrong in our country to drink under the age of 21. Is that a fact, or is that just somebody's opinion? What about killing another unjustly? That's something we all consider, or at least hope we all consider, to be a universal truth: that killing another unjustly, as in murder, is wrong. Is that fact, or is that opinion? So the slippery slope that students are starting down is that these things are becoming a little bit more based on opinion. So then when we get into things like same-sex marriage: fact or opinion?

5:36 So as you stand on a main stage, or you stand in front of a group of students, and you start talking about what Scripture says is fact, they are being taught that these things are often just opinion. That is why talking about morality is vitally, vitally important in terms of helping them establish what our moral compass actually is and where we get our morals from.

One Johnny tall

6:07 So here's a little story I like to tell when it comes to morality. It's a story about little Johnny. Little Johnny is a first or second grader who gets an assignment from school to go home and measure how tall he is. He fumbles around the house, trying to figure out how to measure

himself, so that he can go back to school and be a huge success and get a great grade and all those wonderful things. He scrambles all over the house and can't figure out anything, and then finally he has this massively, beautifully wonderful idea.

6:36 He runs to school the next day, and all the little boys and girls are going up to the front of the class. Some say, "I'm this tall according to my dad," and "I'm this many basketballs high," and all these other different objects. Then Johnny gets up in front of the classroom, big smile, beaming, and says, "I'm one Johnny tall." The teacher kind of looks at him and reacts, and Johnny didn't pass the assignment, because we have no idea how tall Johnny really is. Johnny will never be more or less than one Johnny tall, no matter how big Johnny actually gets in the future.

7:13 We can't use ourselves to measure ourselves. We need something beyond us, something external to us, and morality functions the same way. And what's beautiful about morality, as much as it is difficult to follow what God desires for us to do, is that the fact that we have morals, the fact that we understand right from wrong, helps us see who God is. It points us to God. It gives us evidence for God, because we need something beyond ourselves to understand what the difference between right and wrong is.

What you can do

7:46 So what can we do? There's a lot that's cautionary in all of that, so what can you actually do? Well, the first thing you can do is approach all of this first and foremost with grace and with love. Remember, most of your students, and I hope all of your students, really are just trying to love their friends and love people and be tolerant and get along and live peacefully among everybody else. I'm sure that's the case with almost all, if not all, of your students. So they're not trying to be malicious. They're not necessarily trying to defy authority. Approach them with a tremendous amount of grace and a tremendous amount of love, and listen. Listen to the reasons they're giving. That doesn't mean don't challenge those reasons, but make sure that you thoroughly, thoroughly listen to why they're saying what they're saying.

8:35 Secondly, know where they're coming from. Talk to them about where they're hearing their ideas: which classes, even which teachers. Is it at home? Is it online? Is it TV and media? Where are they getting these ideas from? Now, that doesn't mean you want to tell them, "All your ideas are stupid." You just want to hear where they're from, and hear again why they believe those things and why they think those things are true, and help them work through what those thoughts actually are. It's no different from helping you guys work through all of these topics, answering great questions and asking more great questions and trying to figure things out. You want to help students navigate this a little bit, rather than just shoot them down.

9:16 And finally, don't be afraid to challenge their thinking. Some students might come at you a little bit. Some students might get a little bit aggressive. Some might just shut down inside themselves if they feel like their opinion is not valued or not being heard. That's okay, as long as you draw that back out of them, and don't get offended if a student kind of comes at you.

Challenge their thinking, but do so again in love and in understanding, and by listening and taking the time necessary.

9:48 And make sure that this is communicated to your small group leaders, because in that context, in that community, in the community that you are trying to build within your youth groups, it is so, so important that those students feel like they can open up, and that they feel like they can offer that opinion and be accepted, but also be challenged.